

We would sooner die without our technology, than acknowledge its harm. Human civilization has reduced its role to that of a mindless train, bound to the track of “progress”, fueled by the rise of technology: “And in this sense, all Americans are Marxists, for we believe nothing if not that history is moving us toward some preordained paradise and technology is the force behind that movement” (Neil Postman, *Amusing Ourselves To Death*). We have unquestioningly built our entire social and professional structure upon the idea that the quality of our lives can be equated to the improvement of our tools. The world today, much like Postman’s Marxists, believes that utopia is but a single revolution away. The only difference is that the Marxist of the past believed the commune was inevitable, whereas the worshipper of technology believes the same for the singularity. I call this phenomenon the Great American Train. I seek to illuminate the reality of the situation, and to highlight the true magnitude of the truth: The rapid rise of technology has been implemented as a means of control against society because it has infiltrated civilization as a tool of surveillance.

Despite the ubiquitous nature of technology, its benefits are only held by a narrow minority. On one hand, the effects and influence of technology are literally impossible to avoid, while on the other hand, its advantages and disadvantages are never evenly distributed among the population. (Postman, 3). It seems simple to dismiss the disadvantages, the *harm* of technology, as a product of participation within it. This line of reasoning however ignores the fact that technology is *ecological*, and it wholly affects any environment it inhabits (Postman, 3). Whether one chooses to utilize a technology or not is irrelevant in its ability to affect them. In this new environment, this age of information, it is the common public who are reduced to mere numerical objects, and it is the numerical objects who bear the brunt of technology’s countless disadvantages (Postman, 3). As a result, “The winners, which include among others computer companies, multi-national corporations, and the nation state...” (Postman, 3) are highly incentivized to encourage continued usage of this technology that inequitably affects everyone. It is clear: the Great American Train has a clear distinction between the first and coach class. And as technology progresses at breakneck speed, we fail to question how much less our lives have improved in comparison to the pace of this train’s speed. It isn’t just a question of how much we have been helped, but rather how much we have been harmed. We are being watched: “Big Other. It is a ubiquitous networked institutional regime that records, modifies, and commodifies everyday experience from toasters to bodies [...]

annihilates the freedom achieved by the rule of law” (Zuboff, 81). Zuboff’s discovery is a chilling example of technology’s disadvantages being used against the common people. It matters little what we know or what we want, the fact remains: the technology that society has become dependent upon is being used to watch us. Dissidents of this theory should remember the words of Stafford Beers: The purpose of a system is what it does. When surveillance technology is introduced into a system, its inherent ecological nature entails that everyone within that system is surveilled. The benefits of this result are reserved only for the ones who introduced and controlled that surveillance.

Some may question why it matters that the Great American Train is the cause of surveillance. To understand the gravity of this situation, we must remind ourselves of the source. Because the government, who introduced this surveillance technology, stands to gain a lot through surveillance, it has compromised our privacy. Surveillance is introduced to the environment under the guise of security, especially “historical developments, such as wars, terrorist attacks, and crises” (Tau, 92). This “security” is touted as a pendulum, swinging towards increasing surveillance in security, and swinging the other way in times of peace and calm (Tau, Page 92). This narrative greatly benefits the government, which, as a clear winner from the benefits of technology, would want to convince the losers, its constituents, of the merits of surveillance. A particularly illuminating example is TSA PreCheck: “The flying public had a choice: they could submit themselves to additional vetting, including providing extensive background information, proof of identity, and biometrics [...] If they had objections [...] get physically screened” (Tau Page 108). The people, even the critics, are led to believe that the Gordian Knot of privacy and security is cut with choice (Tau, 110). This idea of the pendulum “swinging back” and of the “choice” is a total fabrication; rather the only change is in the public visibility of the government’s surveillance: “If a state really did start cracking down [...] all of this data could be used to identify and convict that person -- or anyone who aided them” (Tau Page 491). Those who submit themselves to surveillance lose their privacy under the public eye of the government; those who don’t, lose their privacy anyway and are illegally surveilled. Nobody but the winners enjoy the privilege of privacy: “the privilege of disappearing is one that belongs only to the government and its employees, the very wealthy, or the very eccentric” (Tau Page 471). This is not a new development. Although the internet was created with the intention of facilitating counterinsurgent operations against belligerents in foreign nations, it was used just as sternly

against the loudest voices for domestic change throughout the mid to late 20th century: “the Army maintains files on the membership ideology, programs, and practices of virtually every activist political group in the country” (Levine, 30). Massive records were made of innocent Americans without any cause; merely that they supported an ideology the existing administration opposed. The government wishes to know everything about its citizens, and it is doing a phenomenal job --- at infiltrating their privacy. The government created the internet, and from the very start, the purpose of the internet was to surveil. In the modern day, it is one and the same statement to claim that if the internet has breached every civilized corner of the world, so have the watchful eyes of the government.

The result, the *harm*, of surveillance technology is that it oppresses any dissent against the approval of the administration. Surveillance, especially the awareness of perceived surveillance affects behavior and the ability to speak freely: “the effect of being watched is to severely constrain individual choice” (Greenwald, 180). Furthermore, people choose to act in a conformist manner when they know that they’re being watched: “the threat or actuality of government surveillance may psychologically inhibit freedom of speech” (Greenwald, 180). Democracy requires free speech, which is proven impossible under surveillance (Greenwald 192). This has little to do with what we are told about our surveillance, whether it be for safety, defense, or some other excuse. What is conveyed matters far less in the long run than that which brings the message, for the ecological and societal impact that technology brings holds a deeply profound effect upon its users: “the personal and social consequences of any medium -- this is, of any extension of ourselves, --- result from the new scale that is introduced into our affairs by each extension of ourselves, or any new technology” (McLuhan, 1). It doesn’t matter what we are told the surveillance is used for. When surveillance technology is introduced, and it sweeps over the entire environment, the world becomes a prison. Inside this prison, the government can’t watch everyone at once, but everyone feels as though they’re being watched, so they modify their behavior as though they’re always being watched. And this is the death of democracy.

Technology is not something one can opt out of: participation in civilization, and in western democracy, entails participation in a society of surveillance. In order to access the convenience of society, one “chooses” (albeit

unwillingly) to be watched and observed, and it is this very admission that leads to widespread behavior change, suppressing dissent before it even starts, conditioning society to align with the powers that be, through the technology they worship. Although the long term effects of such surveillance must be further researched, it is clear that effects are there, and they are dire. The Great American Train must be derailed immediately. I opened this essay claiming that we would rather die without our technology, before we acknowledged its harm. Perhaps this statement holds much truer than you might have initially believed. Our very minds are being occupied, and if we allow technology to progress without considering firmly its ramifications, I leave you with the words of Dave Mustaine: "Next thing you know, they'll take our thoughts away."